



The Poor Man's Guardian was established by Henry Hetherington in 1830. It was a time when radical sentiment in England had been re-awakened by the July revolution in France.

There were many hundreds of radical pamphlets and newspapers published at this time, often with provocative anti-Establishment titles; all of them were bound by law to pay the newspaper stamp tax, but none of them did, so they were known collectively as the Unstamped, and their campaign to remove the Stamp Tax was labelled the War of the Unstamped. They all had difficulties in distribution, since booksellers were not interested in handling products with such low margins, especially if they met with the disapproval of magistrates and clergymen. All of these papers operated under the harsh provisions of the Six Acts passed in 1819 following the Peterloo Massacre.

The Poor Man's Guardian was the most successful of these publications. Hetherington was also pursuing an energetic programme of public lectures to working-class and radical groups, lecturing them on the right to vote, and the wrong done to them by excessive taxation, citing the pensioners, priests and warmongers these taxes went to support.

The first page normally had a long leading article. The rest of the paper carried reports of court cases, particularly under the Six Acts, lists of Victims of the Odious Six Acts, and reports or notices of such organisations as the National Union of the Working Class, the Fund in Aid of

the Wives, Children of the Men in Lancaster Castle and the Meeting of the Co-operative Congress.

The Poor Man's Guardian set out to beat the Law and to make money and was broadly successful in both objectives.

Its vendors flooded the Houses of Correction, its circulation was higher than nearly all the stamped newspapers, and in 1836 the Chancellor of the Exchequer was reluctantly compelled to reduce the Stamp Tax from four pence to just one penny.

This must be accounted the most successful pressure group campaign of the decade; there were of course many other pressure groups, but they took much longer to achieve their objectives. It also turned out to be the training ground for most of the activists and

journalists who later served in the Chartist movement.

The Unstamped made money. The money that came to the Victim Fund and later to the proprietors was used to support other working-class causes, such as the relief of unionists on strike, the fathers and families of Tolpuddle, and to help Lovett when his property was seized because he would not join the militia.

The Unstamped was a political movement, a crusade for the vote and the cheap dissemination of knowledge.

Although the Poor Man's Guardian only lasted for four years until 1835, it had a powerful influence on radical journalism at a critical period, and thus had an influence much greater than its short life would suggest.

Friends, Brethren, and Fellow-Countrymen,
OUR "appeal," as it is called—or rather the appeal of our friends—has turned out as we anticipated:—the conviction of Messrs. Birnie, Hall, and Robinson has been confirmed:—it has been decided by their "sapient worships," that distinct and nameless papers written by the same author, and published irregularly, form only one connected paper, bearing one and the same name, and published at stated periods—or, in fine, that the papers written by the "POOR MAN'S GUARDIAN," are within the meaning of *Castlereagh's Act*. Be it so; we wished to avoid "the law" as we would a very nuisance; we wished—though at great inconvenience—to keep as close as possible without actually trespassing on the common of which this act of tyranny has deprived us,—but we find it impossible; "the law" is made behind our backs—without our consent—kept secret from us—and when discovered, is unintelligible,—or, whether intelligible or not, it is to be interpreted by the paid servants of those who enforce it—and, consequently, escape from it is hopeless! Be it so, we say: we are prepared for the fight; it is a mere legal one on the part of our persecutors, but a moral one on ours; we know that we must suffer, but we are content to do so for the benefit of our fellow-creatures; we have before our eyes the fatal examples of all who have ever advocated the truth; but we shrink not from the worst, be our reward the cross of agony itself, on which Christ expiated his "SEDITION;" and be our doctrines, like his—pure and just as they are—rejected by all mankind; or, be they like his, only received to be distorted—even by those who profess the most to venerate them—into an authority for every species of rapacity and injustice—still we are prepared. Better—far better not to be, than be as we are! Yes, we buckle on our armour of patience and perseverance—we draw forth our sword of reason, and we brave the whole host of tyranny! Defiance is our only remedy;—we cannot be a slave in all: we submit to much—for it is impossible to be wholly consistent—but we will try, step by step, the power of RIGHT against MIGHT, and we will begin by protecting and upholding this grand bulwark and defence of all our rights—this key to all our liberties—THE FREEDOM OF THE PRESS—the press, too, of the IGNORANT and the POOR! we have taken upon ourselves its protection, and we will never abandon our post: we will die rather.
The fight is begun, and we must cast off the trammels both of disguise and fear; we cannot avoid the struggle, and we must meet it manfully:—no more evasion; we will not trespass, but deny the authority of our "lords" to enclose the common against us; we will demand our right, nor treat but with contempt the despotic "law" which would deprive us of it; we will trample it under our feet—and resist to the last any power that may attempt to enforce it.
To you—friends and brethren—you whose cause we are advocating—whose rights we demand—whose liberties we defend—whose interests we espouse—to you we now appeal, not to let us fight our perilous battle singlehanded; we look to you for support; we ask you not to incur danger or expense—we desire not the risk of interests or person—we ask you merely to purchase, with your weekly pennies, and read, and mark, and learn, and inwardly digest, our "newspaper," to be called henceforward "THE POOR MAN'S GUARDIAN;" which will contain "news, intelligence, and occurrences," and "remarks and observations thereon," and "upon matters in Church and State, tending, decidedly, to excite hatred and contempt of the Government and Constitution of the tyranny of this country, as BY LAW established," and also "to vilify the ABUSES of Religion"—and will be "printed in the United Kingdom, for sale, and published periodically" (every Saturday) "in yearly parts and weekly numbers, at intervals not exceeding twenty-six days, and will not exceed two sheets, and will be published for a less sum than Sixpence" (to wit) the sum of ONE PENNY, "exclusive of the duty imposed by the 38 Geo. III. c. 78, and the 60 Geo. III. c. 9," or any other acts whatsoever, and despite the "laws" or the will and pleasure of any tyrant or any body of tyrants whatsoever, any thing hereinbefore, or any where-else, contained to the contrary notwithstanding.
MIDDLESEX SESSIONS, Saturday, July 2.
(Before Francis Conit, and seven or eight Magistrates.)
PENNY PAPERS.
Henry Hetherington appealed against the conviction obtained by the Commissioners of Stamps before the PAID Magistrates of Bow-street Police-Office.